



Indian wrestlers, the latter were also eager to test themselves against top international opponents.

"Unless we are regularly in the Indian team, most of us only get a few chances to compete against international wrestlers. It is only when you wrestle against them that you get an understanding of what your level is. At the PWL, every international wrestler has won major medals, so it's a big challenge to face them," says Kaliraman.

And the internationals weren't treating it like an exhibition.

"There's a two-kilo cushion for every weight category, which is the norm in international competition, but every wrestler has to make weight before their bouts. Making weight is one of the hardest things in international wrestling. The fact that everyone in the PWL had to make the weight limit meant we were all taking the competition seriously.

The only advantage is that we had to make weight in the morning and only wrestled at night, which gave us a long time to recover, unlike in international wrestling, where we have to wrestle very shortly after

presenting our weight," says Kaliraman.

Kaliraman, though, wouldn't trade it. He considers his win against Ochir a milestone towards his ultimate achievement: winning a medal at the 2026 Asian Games.

"Tulga is an Asian Games champion. It's only if I beat him that I will be able to win a medal myself. *Pehle kami thi* (I had some weakness in my game in the past). That's why I lost to him at last year's Asian Championships. So, to be able to beat him in India gives me a lot of confidence that I can beat other top players when the chance comes," he says.

But the bouts weren't the only takeaway.

"We competed in the League for about three weeks. That's a lot of time in which you can observe other wrestlers. I've never competed in the Olympics, but in my team, there were wrestlers who had. Even if you can't always communicate with them, you can still learn a lot from the way these wrestlers prepare for their bout, their technique and their diet. There's a knowledge exchange that happens," says Sujeet.

In the spotlight: Haryana Thunders' Neha Sangwan (left) wrestles at PWL 2026, calling the League a rare chance to be seen on TV. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

That proximity builds belief as well. Former junior Worlds bronze medallist Neha might have had an excellent league, beating Godinez and European medallist Roksana Zasina over the course of the competition, but she says what was particularly memorable was being around Susaki.

"Susaki was in my team. At first, I was very shy of her because she's such a legend in wrestling. I didn't even know how I'd speak to her. But she was very open and friendly. I lost a very close match (to current Indian team member Manisha Bhanwala). She came to me and said I did very well and I had a long way to go. It gave me a lot of belief that Susaki thought so highly of me. When the League ended, Susaki told me that I should come to Japan and train with her. I told her I'd try to come to Japan, but I'd also come to Los Angeles for the Olympics and wrestle alongside her there," she says.